

"Would AI be conscious?" is the new hot question in the town. This week ChatGPT 4.6 Sol got launched and a new standard of intelligence is set with it. Many people marvel at its ability to think and answer intelligently. It almost seems like it is more and more becoming a "being" capable of understanding, contextualizing and solving many great problems. Perhaps more so, it is its emotional intelligent aspect that's even more surprising. In midst of all of this, a question is being raised about its consciousness, ~~does~~ is it aware of its own existence? Plenty of intellectuals, although still a minority, including Dawkins increasingly find themselves placing AI in the conscious circle of beings. With inevitable improvements in the models in the years to follow, it is perhaps a good time to inquire on the topic of consciousness, how it relates to intelligence and how can we recognize it.

Let's start by defining the two concepts first, From my understanding, Intelligence pertains to the ability of understanding and performing complex tasks. An Iron (Pressing iron) can be categorized intelligent if it can actively sense the temperature and perhaps the fabric too and adjust its



operation based on that. Consciousness, on the other hand, is a much unnamed concepts and relates to an individual's ability to be aware of its own existence. It is the sense you feel when you look at the mirror, or you close one eye and look (focus) on the silhouette of your eyebrows and nose, and you feel like peeling out of a window. Its the comical concept you find in superhero movies or cartoons when two characters exchange their bodies. Thus in a way "Consciousness is to be, while intelligence is the ability to do stuff".

But what makes us conscious in the first place? Is it the mesh of neurons in our brain? Is it the specific pattern of electrons transfer b/w them? Or is it something non-physical that eludes the physical universe? If it pertains to neurons, then what if we copy paste the exact structure, would it be coping consciousness? If I start replacing the neurons in your brain with exact electronic replicas, at what point would you cease to be you? How long can I go before Ashir forgets that he is Ashir? What happens when all the neurons are done replaced? Atleast we can say that consciousness isn't in your bgs, or heart or livers, because people loose or replace



them and they are still them. If consciousness were to be found in the physical domain, then it got to be associated with brain. However, even if in the best case scenario, we are able to identify the parts of brain associated with it, it still wouldn't explain 'What is consciousness'?

Perhaps at this point it would be worthwhile to try to understand the development of consciousness.

Definitely early bacteria and eukaryotic lifeform was not conscious? Then perhaps it got developed over the years somehow. Its one thing to be intelligent and search for food, shelter and reproduction - intelligent serves the evolutionary purpose pretty neatly. But to me, its still unclear if any evolutionary purpose is filled by consciousness. Ontologically, conscious serves no purpose what couldn't have been filled by intelligence. Here perhaps its is important to mention that we often find intelligence and conscious together, it should not be assumed as a universal rule. No one would particularly question the consciousness of retarded people or people in coma (although a case could be made to question all external consciousness). At this point, consciousness, to me, feels like a concept of extraordinary nature, that would require some



higher existence for its presence beyond physical constructs.

Preluding to the comment made previously, there can be good reasons to question any external evidence of conscious. I can think & I can feel my existence, thus I know that I am aware of my existence. But no such conclusions could be made about others. For me, there is no feasible way to recognize that others are conscious. Cogito, ergo sum (I think, therefore I am) as proclaimed by descartes perhaps puts it better.

Coming back to AI, I would interpolate/interplate that no amount of intelligence or mirroring of human like emotions could establish the consciousness of AI. For it to be conscious, it would require an ability to recognize its existence & as of now nor I nor anyone else in the world really understands where and this ability comes from. It is probably not ~~the~~ just the neurons & their structure that AI could copy.

To Summarize,

- ① Consciousness is "to be", intelligence is "to do"
- ② In all likelihood, consciousness need a higher explanation than neurons, evolution or physical constructs.
- ③ Although we have good reasons to believe others are conscious, no good reason for AI exists ~~now~~ yet.